From . . .

Courage: Daring Poems for Gutsy Girls

By Gypsee Yo (Jonida Beqo); Mindy Nettifee; Jeanann Verlee and Daphne Gottlieb

Girl with Red Bicycle By Gypsee Yo (Jonida Beqo) (Pg 160)

The girl with the red limping bicycle
and scraped knees and hands wipes
tears with the hem of her dress, sore alone.

By now she knows boys
will always push her out
of the way, rather than lose
to a girl who is good at everything.

Boys, brothers, cousins, and friends
immune to the spell of blooming flowers
on summer frocks, unimpressed
with quick tongue and wit, tell her
the likes of her all die alone.

No man would chain his heart to hers,

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an anchor diving too deep to rescue.

The strap of her torn sandal,
unstitched like her pride, tugs her
ankle by the reins on the long way
home, that humbling walk across hot
pavement soft as bruised flesh.

Across the rooster yard of boyhood cacophony
the bicycle chain drags on the ground like a white flag.

But she squeezes her fists until knuckle-white
hands become walls her pride can lean on.

Let them sweat trying to catch
my hair in the wind. I will ride.

I don't care if their feet never leave the shore.
I will always dive, headfirst and unafraid.

No matter how deep the anchor plunges
I will always rescue myself.

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INTRODUCTION

Courage is not a random act of bravery . . . running into a burning building or fighting crime. It is not reserved for heroes, or soldiers or men. Today, I'd like you to think about the concept of courage in a different way. Something I'll call "everyday courage."

Everyday courage is choosing to be brave when we are scared. Everyday courage is working to be better today than we were yesterday. Everyday courage isn't a destination - it's a choice. A choice that boys are often applauded for, and a choice that girls and women make quietly multiple times a day. A million times in their lives.

Envision these poetry snapshots of everyday courage and you may just see yourself, your mother, your sister, your friend.

These are poems from Courage: Daring Poems for Gutsy Girls by Gypsee Yo, Mindy Nettifee, Jeanann Verlee and Daphne Gottlieb

The First Time I Hit a Boy by Mindy Nettifee (Pg 64)

It doesn't matter that I smile too big and too much,

or that my looks shout warning like a poodle shouts guard dog:

he was dumb enough to say cruel things about my sister

to my face. *Hey, how come you turned out so pretty*

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and she turned out so butt ugly? and then POP! KABLAM!

or, you know, however the comic book boys would say it –

I swung. Hard. And did not miss.

There's not much else to the story.

I'd never met my fist, and then I did.

I was twelve.

I had barely tasted anger.

It was like a mouth full of copper pennies.

Hate wishes.

The other kids just froze there in circle around us,

their mouths opening on their hinges then rusting there.

It hurt like hell when his braces grated my knuckles,

and we both cried out like girls, though he squeaked more

from trying to hold it in and looked genuinely hurt

when he asked *what did you do that for?*

I was speechless, because I knew, but I didn't know.

I was as surprised as he was

to find I had fuses, to discover them blown.

Everyone stared and stared for the longest time

and then a few of the other boys started to laugh,

doubled over even.
There was a trickle of coins on the sidewalk
and then, *then* he was changed forever.

Fury and pity flickered on and off in me.
This was also the first time I learned
there were a thousand strangers inside of me.
Some of them were violent.
The only one with an answer to his question
hadn't yet learned to speak.

Swarm by Jeanann Verlee (Pg 73)

Learn how to say "no."

Cram that word inside your mouth,
the whole thing, make sure all of it
gets in there. Let it walk on your tongue.
Practice with it in the mirror, push it
out, make faces, learn to love the salt
and bitter of it. Teach it to perch on your lip,
buzz, collect pollen from your sugary gloss.
Make it swarm between your cheeks.

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Then, when the days come (there will be
many) where he pushes too hard, speaks
too sweetly, when the hand at your thigh
draws a thump in your stomach, when
the gremlin inside whispers it's not
worth the fight, says you can barter
for your worth tomorrow, when your ribs
shrink, when he unfurls his Almighty Smile,
when four come at you at once, when
you love someone else, when the bar
is closing and your name becomes Take
What I Can Get, when the girls hate you
anyway, when you want him until the burn
if only he wore a different face --

pull back your lips, bare the teeth you have
sharpened to their perfect points, flick
your stinger tongue, set free your swarm.

Disciple by Mindy Nettifee (Pg 147-148)

The best advice I ever got about how to heal
came from a beleaguered camp counselor
who found herself suddenly surrounded

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by a flock of heaving sobbing twelve year old girls.
It had been billed as a session on conflict resolution,
an alternative to wood cookie crafts, or horseshoes,
and maybe she should have seen it coming,
how water seeks the cracks in any dam.

One girl had been brutally sexually assaulted
by the preschool director, and had not slept
through the night alone since.
One had been molested by her foster brother,
who sliced his arms with scissors in the bedroom dark.
One had been strangled by her own mother,
who later found God and apologized,
and then punished her for not offering up

the fish and loaves of forgiveness instantly,
the forgiveness which her mother had been promised
by some pastor that she deserved now, and would receive
through the mysterious machines of grace;
the kind that multiplied and magnified and
fed the endless hunger at the center of things.
There were other stories.
Abuse is a word that sounds powerful in your head

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and goes limp the moment you speak it,
hanging like a soaked wet curtain
around the things we cannot bear to know.
I don't remember the counselor's name, or
what she looked like, just that she was an enormous
buoy of a woman. That her voice was deep
and calm and quavered at all the right turns.
That she sat in a way that trained gravity.

How unprepared she must have felt,
to see the sharks swimming in our eyes,
to have been handed the heavy anchors
of our trust. What well of strength did she draw from?
What inheritance of bedrock and granite and spine?
What gospel stolen from the bent melted steel of kitchen
knives?
She absorbed every blow of every word.
When we had finished, when we were softened

by confession, she took a breath and began.
Without getting into the kind of details that get attention,
she told us the story of her own early ruin,
of the lifetimes of gentle obligation it left in its wake.

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The heart and the mind and the body
might never align on the requirements of joy.
The mind must be taught patience with the heart.
The heart must learn faith from the body.

The body must be tended lovingly and unwaveringly, an infant.
The heart will take its own sweet time, and cannot be rushed.
"Just fake it 'till you feel it," she told us,
and like that, gave us permission
to put on the tight masks of adulthood,
to build walls around what was
too tender and shocked;
to survive.

In Case You Ever Need It, It is Here by Daphne Gottlieb (Pg 74-75)

Take this as yours
Rip this from the book
or make a copy
fold it in half
and half again
and put it in your wallet
or between the mattress and the box spring
or taped under your desk
so it is there
if.

Know this: what happened
to your body
to your head
to your heart
is not your fault.
It is not something you
deserved or caused.

It is like blaming yourself
for someone hitting your hand
with a hammer.
(if that person is you,
put the hammer down.
Let it be an accident.
Let it be the end.)

The body, heart, brain knows

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how to heal. It knows how to knit
back together. How to suture
and secure. Let it do what it does.
Your body is yours. Your body
will always be yours.

You are not what happened.
Your whole life
is not just this. You do not speak
a language made of this, this is
not your name.

Your name is your own.

Let your name be
The name of someone who
can do the unthinkable:
Stands up and keeps moving.
You are standing. You are taking
a shower and eating breakfast.
You are going to classes
or going to work. You are doing
impossibly hard things. Keep going

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and keep going and there
is summer. Laugh even if it is
with rage. Open your mouth
and your fists. Tell the truth.
Tell a friend. Listen to someone
else's heart. It is beating
a miracle. You are
Both here.

When scars are new,
They shine. Be all the glitter
You need.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Authors: ***Gypsee Yo (Jonida Beqo); Mindy Nettifee; Jeanann Verlee and Daphne Gottlieb***
Book: Courage: Daring Poems for Gutsy Girls
ISBN: 978-1938912207
Publisher: Write Bloody Publishing
Date (Month/Year): March 2014

AWARD HISTORY

CO State Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier - MS